

# Session 13: The Higher Gifts

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## Key Takeaways

- The characteristics of speaking in tongues as a spiritual gift is that they are not spoken to people but to God, and they are spoken in the Spirit. This gift both edifies the person speaking and allows them to utter mysteries.
- The spiritual gift of prophesy is spoken to people for edification, encouragement, consolation, and building up the Church.
- Paul encourages speaking in tongues, but, even more, he wants the Corinthians to prophesy, imploring people to use intelligible words for the sake of helping others.

## Desiring Spiritual Gifts

Paul is enthusiastic about love and spiritual gifts, but he uses different verbs for each. In 1 Corinthians 14:1, “Earnestly pursue love” is διώχω (Greek: *dioko*) which has connotations of to pursue or to hunt down. “Earnestly desire spiritual gifts” is ζηλόω (Greek: *zeloo*) which is more like “be eager to possess” or “jealously seek.”

So they are to earnestly pursue love and jealously desire spiritual gifts, especially that they might prophesy.

## Tongues Versus Prophecy

Note the contrast Paul draws between the gifts of tongues and prophecy. Tongues are spoken not to people but to God, spoken in the Spirit, uttering mysteries, and edifying the speaker. Prophecy is spoken to people for the edification, encouragement, and consolation of the Church.

## What Paul Wants for the Church

Paul expresses his desire that the Corinthians speak in tongues, but he desires more that they would prophesy.

What reason does he give for the one prophesying as “greater” than the one speaking in tongues? Tongues is profitable if it is only one of a group of gifts. In addition to the gift of tongues, the church needs revelation, knowledge, prophecy, and teaching.

## Chaos at Corinth

In Chapter 13, Paul has used the image of instruments (of a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal) and he uses it again here. If an instrument isn’t clear and the notes distinct, it’s pointless listening. Paul is telling them

they need to use intelligible words more than tongues.

### **1 Corinthians 14:11-12 NIV\***

<sup>11</sup> If then I do not grasp the meaning of what someone is saying, I am a foreigner (Greek: *barbaros* / *βάρβαρος*) to the speaker, and the speaker is a foreigner to me. <sup>12</sup> So it is with you. Since you are eager for gifts of the Spirit, try to excel in those that build up the church.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

*Barbaros* is someone who doesn't speak Greek.

From the context of 1 Corinthians 14:13-19, we can infer that the Corinthians were speaking in tongues in a chaotic manner in their gatherings. Likely, multiple people spoke at once in public gatherings with no interpretation.

Paul continues his contrast noting that tongues needs interpreting and, while the spirit is active in prayer, the mind remains unfruitful, whereas intelligible words in prayer or praise engage the mind.

## **Edification and Inclusion**

Paul wants worship at Corinth to be intelligible and orderly for the sake of the “uninstructed.” Verse 16 says the “uninstructed” (Greek: *idiotes* / *ιδιώτης*), which means “amateur,” “unskilled person,” or “outsider.” We do this so someone who is not knowledgeable of the group will be included, edified, and able to say “amen” to the thanksgiving offered. Five intelligible words is better than ten thousand words in a tongue according to Paul.

## **Reflection Question**

Why does Paul refer to the one prophesying as “greater” than the one speaking in tongues in a Corinthian corporate gathering?